

Ten paths: what you study, what job you get, and what it actually pays.

One page per path — the syllabus in plain terms, the job titles it really leads to with named employers, and the money, with a source and a confidence badge on every single figure.

Read this before you read a single number

Salary aggregators disagree with each other by up to 86% on the same role, country and year. Sound designer in Germany came back as €33,810 (PayScale), €52,141 (ERI) and €58,446 (SalaryExpert). Marketing manager in the Netherlands came back as €54,130 and €100,432. Acoustics engineer in Germany came back as €31,321 — twenty thousand euros below the German engineering band it sits inside. These are not different jobs. They are the same job measured by sites with different self-selected samples.

So this document does four things instead of pretending to precision. It **prefers published collective pay scales** — Germany's TV-L and the Dutch university CAO are negotiated, published and verifiable, and a research or public-sector audio job is paid on them exactly. It **prints the spread rather than an average**, because averaging two figures 86% apart manufactures a confidence neither has. It **badges every figure** solid / indicative / weak / no data. And where the data does not exist, it **says so** instead of filling the gap.

The anchors — trust these before anything else in this file

BENCHMARK	GROSS	SOURCE	CONFIDENCE
Germany — TV-L E13 step 1 , the public research-engineer scale a TU Berlin or university audio-lab post is paid on	€4,759.37 / month → €57,112 / yr	published pay scale (April 2026)	solid
Netherlands — CAO Dutch Universities scale 10 (graduate researcher/engineer)	€3,546 – €5,213 / month	published pay scale (1 Jul 2025 table)	solid
Netherlands — CAO scale 11 (senior researcher / lecturer)	€4,728 – €6,349 / month	published pay scale	solid
Berlin — all occupations, gross median	€56,500	StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026	solid
Berlin — IT software developer	€45,500 – €63,800 (avg €53,400)	StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026	solid
Berlin — data scientist	€50,400 – €69,700 (avg €59,400)	StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026	solid
Netherlands — all occupations, gross average	€53,436	CBS national average 2026	solid
Spain — software engineer, 0–2 yrs / 3–6 yrs	€20,000 – €28,000 / €32,000 – €50,000	Michael Page / Manfred guide 2026 (ES)	solid

All ten at a glance

	PATH	BEST-PAID ROLE IT LEADS TO	BEST ANCHOR FIGURE	DATA QUALITY
A	Sound & Music Computing	Audio software / DSP engineer	€57,112 / yr	solid
C	AI / ML for Audio & Music	ML engineer — audio, speech, voice	€50,400 – €69,700 (avg €59,400)	solid
N	Music-Tech Product & Innovation	Product manager	€53,000 – €70,000	indicative
G	Sound Design (film / games / media)	Technical sound designer (games)	€6,700 – €24,250 median band	solid
H	Immersive / Spatial Audio	Spatial audio engineer	€57,112 / yr	solid
R	Live Sound & Event Systems	FOH / monitor engineer	25th pct €32,800 · 75th pct €60,750	indicative
J	Music Business & Management	A&R / label manager	£28,000 – £45,000 · senior £55,000 – £110,000	indicative
L	Music / Creative Entrepreneurship	Founder — label, studio, product, agency	no salary until the venture pays one	no data
AC	Marketing & Brand Management	Marketing analyst → marketing manager	€38,442 – €42,820	indicative
AD	Media & Entertainment Management	Media / content operations manager	€40,000 – €60,000	weak

Where the money and the music genuinely overlap

Three roles pay engineering money and are really about sound: **audio DSP / plug-in engineer** (path A), **ML engineer for audio or speech** (path C), and **technical sound designer** in games (path G — Wwise and FMOD plus scripting). All three are scarce specialisms inside well-paid professions.

You do not have to choose between earning and music. You do have to choose the *technical* half of the music industry over the creative half — which is where your degree already puts you.

And the effect that dwarfs every path here: the same software role pays **€20,000–28,000 starting in Spain** and **€45,500–63,800 in Berlin**. Spain's cheap tuition and low salaries are one fact seen twice.

The two things this research changed my mind about

Game audio pays worse than the aggregators claim. The European games-industry survey puts junior medians at €6,700–24,250 and records that sound-specialist pay *fell* in 2024. The €50,000–58,000 figures on salary sites do not describe a first job.

Music business is shrinking, not just opaque. The 2024–25 layoff cycle cut 1,200+ A&R, marketing and label-services roles globally and compressed mid-level pay by 8–12%. That matters more than any single salary figure on path J.

Sound & Music Computing

What you would actually study

CORE

- Digital signal processing — filters, FFT, convolution, sampling theory, and the real-time constraint that makes audio harder than it looks on paper
- Psychoacoustics: masking, localisation, loudness. What the ear perceives, and therefore what you are allowed to throw away — this is why codecs work
- Music information retrieval: beat and key tracking, transcription, source separation, audio fingerprinting

TOOLS

- C++ with JUCE for plug-ins (VST3/AU), Python with librosa/PyTorch for analysis, MATLAB in the more traditional departments, Max/MSP or Pure Data for prototyping
- Version control, profiling and latency budgeting — the software-engineering half you already have, which most of your classmates will not

THESIS

- Typically half software, half experiment: build the thing, then measure whether it works on listeners or on a dataset. Your engineering degree makes the build half easy; the measurement half is what you will actually learn

Job opportunities this opens

Audio software / DSP engineer	Plug-ins, audio engines, embedded audio. The most direct destination. Employers: Native Instruments and Ableton (Berlin), Bose, Dolby, Sonos, Focusrite, Steinberg
Music-tech R&D engineer	Prototype-to-product research inside an audio company. Employers: Spotify audio team, Dolby, Fraunhofer IIS (the MP3/AAC institute)
MIR / machine-listening engineer	Recommendation, tagging, stem separation, detection. Employers: Spotify, Deezer, Epidemic Sound, Musixmatch
Embedded audio engineer	DSP on constrained hardware — instruments, cars, hearables. Employers: Automotive audio, hearing-aid firms, instrument manufacturers
Research engineer → PhD	Paid on a public scale, not a market rate. Predictable and modest. Employers: TU Berlin Audio Communication, UPF MTG, Fraunhofer

What it pays

Germany — research post (TV-L E13)	€57,112 / yr	solid	published pay scale — The floor for a research-engineer job. Published, negotiated, verifiable.
Berlin — industry developer band	€45,500 – €63,800	solid	StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026 — DSP specialists reported at roughly €55,000 – €58,000, i.e. at or above the general band.
Netherlands — CAO scale 10 equivalent	€42,500 – €62,500 / yr	solid	published pay scale — €3,546–5,213/month × 12, plus the customary 8% holiday and 8.3% year-end allowances at universities.
Netherlands — private sector	€50,000 – €85,000	indicative	aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — Sources spread widely; the top of this range is senior or big-tech, not a graduate offer.
Spain	€20,000 – €28,000 start · €32,000 – €50,000 at 3–6 yrs	solid	Michael Page / Manfred guide 2026 (ES) — Recruiter placement data, so it reflects real offers rather than self-reporting.

The honest verdict

The best earnings path here AND the best subject fit — the rare case where you are not trading money for meaning. Audio DSP is a scarce specialism inside a well-paid profession, and your software-engineering degree is the entry ticket most applicants lack.

AI / ML for Audio & Music

What you would actually study

CORE

- Machine learning properly: architectures, optimisation, regularisation, evaluation that survives contact with reality
- Deep learning for sequences and spectrograms — the shapes audio actually takes
- Statistics and experimental design, which is what separates an ML engineer from someone who calls .fit()

TOOLS

- PyTorch, the HuggingFace stack, MLOps and deployment, cloud training pipelines
- Data engineering — genuinely most of the job, and the part courses under-teach

THESIS

- Point it at audio deliberately or you will graduate a generic ML engineer. UGR's SigMAT group (speech, voice synthesis) and UPF's Music Technology Group are the two labs in this dataset where an audio thesis is actually supervisable

Job opportunities this opens

ML engineer — audio, speech, voice	Speech recognition, TTS, generative audio, voice cloning. Employers: ElevenLabs-type startups, Spotify, Deezer, Sony CSL Paris
Data scientist / ML engineer, general	The fallback that hires constantly in every city. Employers: Effectively every mid-size company in Berlin and Amsterdam
Research engineer, audio lab	Between academia and product. Employers: Fraunhofer IIS, Sony CSL, university labs
MLOps / platform engineer	Higher paid, less glamorous, always in demand.
Applied scientist	Usually needs a PhD; the research master's is the on-ramp.

What it pays

Berlin — data scientist	€50,400 – €69,700 (avg €59,400) StepStone Gehaltsreport 2026 — The best-paid band found anywhere in Berlin in this research.	solid
Germany — research post (TV-L E13)	€57,112 / yr published pay scale — As above.	solid
Netherlands	€55,000 – €100,000+ aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — Aggregators quote €101,522 as a national average, which is not credible against a CBS national average of €53,436. Treat anything above €75,000 as senior or big-tech.	weak
Spain	€25,000 – €35,000 start; AI carries a premium Michael Page / Manfred guide 2026 (ES) — DigitalES reports a structural shortage — 8,500 unfilled cloud roles — which pushes AI pay above the general software band.	indicative

The honest verdict

Highest ceiling and the most portable qualification in this document. The risk is not employment, it is drift: nothing about an AI master's keeps you in music. Only a deliberate thesis and a lab with an audio group will.

Music-Tech Product & Innovation

What you would actually study

CORE

- Prototyping and user research — building in order to learn, not in order to ship
- Interaction and product design method: from a vague brief to a testable artefact
- Business modelling, validation and pitching — usually assessed by a real pitch

TOOLS

- Figma, rapid hardware prototyping, whatever stack the project needs

THESIS

- Almost always a real product with real users, often with an industry partner. This is the path where a music-tech product IS the degree

Job opportunities this opens

Product manager	Music-tech startups, hardware, platforms. Engineering background is a strong asset. Employers: Native Instruments, Ableton, Bandcamp-type platforms, hardware startups
Interaction / UX engineer	Where design meets code — your hybrid is the whole job description.
Innovation consultant	Corporate innovation teams and agencies.
Founder	Several of these programmes are explicitly built as venture incubators. Employers: Mondragon LEINN, ESMT, TU Berlin IMES

What it pays

Berlin — product roles	€53,000 – €70,000 aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — Sits near or slightly above the developer band; equity is common and unquantifiable.	indicative
Netherlands — UX / product	€45,000 – €75,000 aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor	indicative
Spain — UX / product designer	€22,000 junior · €30,000 mid · €50,000+ senior Indeed / Jooble Spain 2026 — Indeed reports a €33,932 average for UX designers in Spain; guides put the working range at €25,000–45,000.	solid
Founder	no salary until the venture pays one — — The honest entry. Upside is uncapped; downside is a year with no income.	no data

The honest verdict

Slightly below pure engineering at the start, above it later IF the venture works. It is the only path where the outcome depends more on what you build than on who hires you.

Sound Design (film / games / media)

What you would actually study

CORE

- Sound design craft: field recording, editing, foley, layering, designing to picture
- Mixing and delivery standards — broadcast loudness, cinema, game middleware
- Narrative and dramaturgy of sound: why a cut works, not just how

TOOLS

- Pro Tools or Reaper, Wwise and FMOD, Dolby Atmos rendering, Unreal/Unity integration

THESIS

- A reel. This path is judged on the reel for the rest of your career, and the degree is mostly a structured excuse to build one with feedback

Job opportunities this opens

Technical sound designer (games)	Wwise/FMOD plus scripting. THE role where your engineering converts directly into money — and the best-paid sub-role on this path. Employers: Guerrilla and Nixxes (Amsterdam), Guerrilla Cambridge, King, Ubisoft Barcelona/Berlin
Sound designer — film / TV / games	Project-based, credit-driven, freelance-heavy.
Audio post engineer / re-recording mixer	Studio-based. Stable if you get on staff. Employers: Post houses in Amsterdam, Madrid, Barcelona
Audio implementer / audio programmer	Between design and engineering.
Foley artist / field recordist	Specialist, small market.

What it pays

Europe — games industry, junior	€6,700 – €24,250 median band	solid	European games-industry employment survey — Across all disciplines. Sound sits in the LOWER half, and the survey records that sound-specialist pay FELL in 2024.
Europe — games industry, mid-level	€13,800 – €47,000	solid	European games-industry employment survey — Programmers are at the top of that band, QA at the bottom. Audio is nearer the middle.
Europe — games industry, senior	€31,000 – €84,000	solid	European games-industry employment survey
Germany — audio engineer	25th pct €32,800 · 75th pct €60,750	indicative	aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — PayScale percentiles, which are more informative than the averages other sites publish.
Germany — sound designer	€33,810 / €52,141 / €58,446	weak	aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — THREE sources, same role, same year, 73% apart. This is the least reliable figure in the document.
Spain — técnico de sonido	€24,198 – €30,036	indicative	Indeed / Jooble Spain 2026 — Indeed and Jooble disagree by 24%.

The honest verdict

The widest pay uncertainty and the most freelance exposure of any path here, and the European games survey says sound pay is falling, not rising. Technical sound design is the exception: it pays like programming because it largely is programming. Pure creative sound design puts you against a large pool that will out-portfolio you, and your engineering counts for little there.

Immersive / Spatial Audio

What you would actually study

CORE

- Ambisonics, binaural rendering, HRTFs, wave field synthesis
- Room and environmental acoustics: measurement, modelling, prediction
- Object-based audio and the Atmos/MPEG-H production chain

TOOLS

- Measurement rigs, anechoic and WFS facilities, Reaper/Pro Tools with spatial toolsets, SPAT and IEM plug-in suites

THESIS

- The most mathematically demanding path in this list. Expect real physics

Job opportunities this opens

Spatial audio engineer	Format and renderer development. Employers: Dolby, Fraunhofer IIS, Sennheiser AMBEO, Apple
Immersive audio specialist	Atmos mixing, VR/AR audio, installations, planetaria.
Acoustic consultant	Buildings, transport, environmental noise. Nothing to do with music — and the most reliable employer on this path. Employers: Arup, Level Acoustics (NL), Spanish consultancies
Audio systems R&D	Loudspeaker and array design. Employers: L-Acoustics, d&b audiotechnik, Meyer Sound

What it pays

Germany — research post (TV-L E13)	€57,112 / yr	solid
	published pay scale — Fraunhofer and university spatial-audio groups pay on public scales.	
Berlin — engineering band	€45,000 – €65,000	indicative
	aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — Tracks the general engineering band.	
Germany — acoustics engineer	€31,321	weak
	aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — ERI's figure, and it contradicts the German engineering band by roughly €20,000. Do not plan on it.	
Netherlands — acoustics research post	€2,901 – €3,707 / month	indicative
	published pay scale — Advertised research-position band, i.e. €34,800 – €44,500 before allowances.	
Spain	€22,000 – €35,000 (consulting)	indicative
	Michael Page / Manfred guide 2026 (ES)	

The honest verdict

A genuinely scarce specialism with a boring, stable fallback attached: acoustic consulting pays steadily and has nothing to do with music. Small field — few employers, so the job picks the city rather than the other way round.

Live Sound & Event Systems

What you would actually study

CORE

- PA and line-array design, coverage prediction, system optimisation and tuning
- Networked audio — Dante, AES67 — plus power, rigging and safety
- Show production workflow and crew management

TOOLS

- L-Acoustics Soundvision, Meyer MAPP, Smaart, DiGiCo and Yamaha consoles

THESIS

- Mostly irrelevant — this trade is learned on real shows, and employers ask what you have toured, not what you wrote

Job opportunities this opens

FOH / monitor engineer	Touring or venue. Freelance is the norm, not the exception.
Systems engineer / system tech	PA design and deployment — the technical top of the trade. Employers: L-Acoustics, Clair Global, Fluge (ES), rental houses
Technical manager — venue or festival	The salaried destination, and the realistic career end-point. Employers: Paradiso and Ziggo Dome (NL), Berlin venues, Primavera/Sónar (ES)
AV systems integrator	Corporate AV: dull, stable, pays better than touring.

What it pays

Germany — audio engineer, percentiles	25th pct €32,800 · 75th pct €60,750	indicative
	aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — The closest usable proxy; live-specific figures were not published by any source found.	
Netherlands — sound engineer	€62,799 / €63,115	weak
	aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — Two aggregators, single-sourced, unverifiable.	
Touring — day rates	€75 – €150 / day (historic examples)	weak
	aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — Portugal and Slovakia examples, not current German or Dutch rates. Illustrates the freelance floor, nothing more.	
Spain — técnico de sonido	€24,198 – €30,036	indicative
	Indeed / Jooble Spain 2026	

The honest verdict

No viable master's exists in Spain, the Netherlands or Berlin — the Dutch provision stops at bachelor and BHT Berlin admits only in the summer semester, which cannot reach September 2027. Treat this as certifications plus real show experience alongside another degree. The pay data is also the thinnest here, which is consistent with a trade that hires on reputation, not credentials.

Music Business & Management

What you would actually study

CORE

- Rights, publishing, licensing and royalty flows — the actual plumbing of the industry
- Live and touring economics; deal structures and contract literacy
- Streaming economics, playlisting, and the data behind both

TOOLS

- Royalty and catalogue systems, market analytics, negotiation practice

THESIS

- Usually a business plan or a market study, frequently with an industry placement

Job opportunities this opens

A&R / label manager	The classic route. Berlin and Amsterdam are real markets. Employers: Sony Music Berlin, indie labels, Warner/Universal Benelux
Rights and publishing manager	Less glamorous, more durable, better paid than A&R. Employers: GEMA (DE), Buma/Stemra (NL), SGAE (ES), publishers
Streaming / catalogue analyst	Where your data skills would command a premium the room lacks. Employers: Spotify, Deezer, distributors, label analytics teams
Artist manager / booking agent	Commission-based. Income follows the roster, not a contract.
Music supervisor	Sync for film, TV, ads. Small field, high competition.

What it pays

UK — A&R base	£28,000 – £45,000 · senior £55,000 – £110,000 indicative UK Music / Chartlex 2026 (UK only) — UK ONLY. Included because it is the only real European market data found — do not assume Berlin, Amsterdam or Madrid match London.
Europe (Spain, NL, Berlin)	no reliable published data found no data — — Searched in three languages. European music-business pay is simply not published.
Sector context	1,200+ A&R, marketing and label-services roles cut globally in the 2024–25 layoff cycle; mid-level pay compressed 8–12% indicative UK Music / Chartlex 2026 (UK only) — This is a shrinking-headcount market, which matters more than any single salary figure.
Artist income	43% of full-time musicians earn under £14,000 / yr solid UK Music / Chartlex 2026 (UK only) — Relevant to the producer half of your ambition, and worth reading twice.

The honest verdict

The weakest salary transparency of any path — and that opacity is the finding. Unpublished pay is usually lower and more variable than the US figures circulating online. Combined with an industry actively cutting these exact roles, this is the highest-risk path in the document. Your data skills are the one thing that would place you above the crowd applying for it.

Music / Creative Entrepreneurship

What you would actually study

CORE

- Venture creation: business models, validation, funding, cap tables
- Cultural policy and how European public money actually moves — grants are a skill
- Managing a creative practice as a business, including the tax and legal shape

TOOLS

- Financial modelling, grant writing, pitching

THESIS

- Usually the venture itself, assessed as a business

Job opportunities this opens

Founder — label, studio, product, agency	The declared purpose of the path.
Cultural programme / venue manager	Salaried, often publicly funded, modest but stable. Employers: Municipal venues, festivals, arts foundations
Arts funding / grants officer	The reliable salaried role this degree opens.
Portfolio freelancer	Several part-incomes rather than one salary — the common reality.

What it pays

Founder	no salary until the venture pays one	no data
	— — The honest answer.	
Cultural-sector employed roles	generally BELOW the national medians on page 1	weak
	— — No specific published figure was found for Spain, the Netherlands or Berlin.	
Relevant instead of a salary	ESMT Panzer Scholarship — €35,000 against €36,000 tuition, plus ten months of Berlin housing	solid
	verified in this project's own funding sweep — Requires under 30, African citizenship and residence, and a founded venture. You meet two of three today.	

The honest verdict

Do not choose this for the salary; there isn't one. Choose it if you intend to build something and want a year of runway, a network and a legal structure while you do. Note the circularity worth exploiting: registering a venture now both starts the business and unlocks €35,000.

Marketing & Brand Management

What you would actually study

CORE

- Consumer behaviour and brand strategy
- Marketing analytics — regression, experiment design, attribution modelling. Your maths is a straightforward advantage in a room that mostly fears it
- Channel and campaign management, pricing, go-to-market

TOOLS

- R or Python for analytics, SQL, GA4, CRM platforms

THESIS

- Usually a company-based project with real data

Job opportunities this opens

Marketing analyst → marketing manager	The quantitative track, and the one that fits you.
Growth / performance marketer	Closest to engineering: measurable, testable, well paid.
Product marketing manager	Bridges product and market — engineering background is valued.
Brand manager	Slower, more corporate, longer ladder. Employers: FMCG and consumer brands
Marketing at a music company	Where the two halves of your ambition could meet. Employers: Labels, streaming platforms, festival marketing

What it pays

Netherlands — entry	€38,442 – €42,820	indicative
aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — PayScale entry-level and early-career figures.		
Netherlands — average	€54,130 vs €100,432	weak
aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — PayScale and SalaryExpert, same role, same year, 86% apart. The lower figure is the credible one against a €53,436 national average.		
Berlin	€45,000 – €60,000	indicative
aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor		
Spain	€22,000 – €35,000	indicative
Michael Page / Manfred guide 2026 (ES)		

The honest verdict

The safety path: broad hiring, predictable pay, and quantitative marketing genuinely rewards your background rather than merely tolerating it. The cost is distance — this moves you furthest from music of any path here.

Media & Entertainment Management

What you would actually study

CORE

- How media organisations are financed, structured and governed
- Audience research and platform economics
- Creative-industries strategy, policy and regulation

TOOLS

- Audience analytics, project and production management

THESIS

- Usually a strategy or case study, often with a media partner

Job opportunities this opens

Media / content operations manager	Streaming platforms, broadcasters, studios.
Programme or product manager, media company	Where your engineering re-enters the picture.
Creative-industries strategist or consultant	Agencies and public bodies.
Distribution / platform partnerships	Commercial, relationship-driven.

What it pays

Netherlands	€40,000 – €60,000	weak
aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor — No published scale found for this role family.		
Berlin	€42,000 – €60,000	weak
aggregator — PayScale / ERI / SalaryExpert / Glassdoor		
Spain	€22,000 – €32,000	weak
Michael Page / Manfred guide 2026 (ES)		

The honest verdict

Sits between marketing and music business and pays like the lower half of marketing. Note the admissions problem too: most of these programmes reject engineering backgrounds on subject grounds and route you through a pre-master, adding a year before you earn anything.